

Understanding the Contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in the Culture, History and Development of Tanzania

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Abstract

The Contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in Culture, History and Development of Tanzania is a project which is ethnical, social and participatory. The project aims at congregating members of the Persian (Iranian) communities with their friends for the purpose of enlightening and enriching culture, history and development in Tanzania to students, visitors and the public in general. The project is for honoring, venerating and celebrating this heritage; thus making it an important project. The Persian (Iranian) communities in Tanzania can be traced back before the coming of the Europeans. They have lived in Tanzania for many years. The Persian (Iranian) communities have been influenced by the indigenous. Nevertheless, the Persian (Iranian) communities have also been subjective to the Tanzanian culture. The Persian (Iranian) communities have been part and parcel of the Tanzanian history. In addition, these communities have considerably contributed in the development of Tanzania.

Despite these contributions, the Museum has never acknowledged the influence of Persian (Iranian) communities in the history and culture of Tanzania. The Museum has not even recognized the input of the Persian (Iranian) communities in the development of Tanzania. As a result the Persian (Iranian) communities have no occasion to be part and parcel of the museum. For this reason, the Persian (Iranian) communities have been not donating both cultural and historical objects, records and information to the museum. These communities have under no circumstances been supporting museum exhibitions and other activities. The communities have by no means attending museum programmes. Consequently, few members of the communities have been visiting the museum.

Having realized these challenges, the museum ought to have the project, namely the *Understanding of the Contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in the Culture, History and Development of Tanzania*. This project will be conducted as follows:

1. The museum will collaborate with the Iranian Embassy to raise funds
2. Gather enough knowledge (objects, records and information)
3. Archive and database this knowledge (objects, records and information)
4. Process this knowledge into exhibition and programmes and

5. Disseminate this knowledge to the public

A museum is an institution which provides service of the community. The core functions of museums are collection (of objects, records and information), documentation preservation, research and public education. Museums have educational programs. The museum programs are important in teaching as supplements in school learning. Unfortunately, the museum has not been performing to its fullest. The contribution of culture, history and development of the Persian (Iranian) communities to Tanzania although they have lived, worked and intermingled with the Tanzanians for many years. This is due to a number of challenges such as limited funds, shortage of staff and equipment, etc.

As a result of these challenges, Tanzanian culture and history have remained vulnerable into 'cold and damp' situation. Deterioration and undergoing of historical and cultural traits is one set of the underlined elements the Persians (Iranians) culture and history in Tanzania is facing. The Persians (Iranians) culture and history in Tanzania has been drawn against its part. Subsequently, some of the elements of the Tanzania history and culture (like these of the Persian/Iranian) have been left behind. Consequently, the project aims at recognizing the Persians (Iranians) culture and history in Tanzania to be very crucial.

This project proposal enables the museum to address questions and problems behind the history and culture of the Persian (Iranian) communities in Tanzania. The drawing of this proposal lies on the fact that the National Museum of Tanzania through the Museum and House of Culture is entitled to collect, preserve/conservate the Tanzanian heritage for public interest. Through this project, the Museum and House of Culture intends to acquire objects, records and information related to cultural and historical elements of the Persian (Iranian) communities in Tanzania and later arrange for discussion, mount the exhibition, organize Iranian-Tanzanian Cultural Festival purposely for conserving/preserving this culture, history and development, to educate and inform children, students and tourists this heritage.

To implement this successfully, the project proposes the mutual collaboration between the National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) and the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania. This proposed mutual collaboration lies on the fact that both the National Museum of Tanzania through Museum and House of Culture and the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania objectives are to conserve/preserve and promote the Persian (Iranian) and Tanzanian heritage for public interest.

The responsibilities of the National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) converge at a point with the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania. The strategic objectives of the National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) also match with the main objectives of the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania. Both institutions are interested with the historical and cultural heritage which must be collected, recorded and documented for both educations through displays and students programs and projects as well as research.

Additionally, both institutions meet in the field during research for one conventional aspect which is the historical and cultural heritage. These institutions converge and match in a line of work to create a necessity for the National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) and the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania to join forces in carrying out this project together. Moreover, the National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) and the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania concurrently realize the challenges encountering the public in the understanding of the contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in the culture, history and development of Tanzania. The National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) and the Embassy of Iran to Tanzania ought to decide on drawing in this proposal which underlines the statement for carrying out this project.

The main goal of this project is to give time and space for cultural and historical practitioners to debate, produce, exhibit and celebrate their heritage in return contribute to the national and international understanding of the Tanzanian culture, history and development.

Background

The National Museum of Tanzania is a body corporate established by an Act of Parliament No. 7 of 1980. Its mandate is to research, document and preserve collection and information of Tanzanian heritage. Moreover, it brings into play the acquired, documented and preserved collections and information for public education and recreation. The National Museum of Tanzania is instituted by seven museums: the National Museum and House of Culture, Village Museum, Natural History Museum, Arusha Declaration Museum, Mwalimu Nyerere's Memorial Museum, Maji Maji Memorial Museum as well as the recently acquired Kawawa Memorial Museum.

The National Museum and House of Culture is the first and largest museum in Tanzania. This Museum was constructed between 1936 to 1938 and made public in 1940. Among other duties, is to acquire, research, preserve and document. It is also charged with interpreting the Tanzanian historical, natural and cultural heritage and making them available to the public for social, scholarly and tourism purposes.

Apparently, the museum hosts archaeological, art, biological, ethnological, historical and paleontological objects from different areas of Tanzania. Evidently, the museum holds permanent galleries on human evolution, history, contemporary art and rock art. Biology and ethnography galleries are under way. The museum consists of open air exhibition including the first and old historical (King George Memorial Museum) building of 1940, Hope Out of Sorrow, Historical tree, Butterfly garden, aquarium and Historical cars. Furthermore, it organizes and coordinates several cultural programmes aiming at educating, preserving and promoting Tanzanian biodiversity, history and culture. Apart from these responsibilities, the museum manages several programme and exhibitions as part of community/ public issues including:

- HIV/AIDS programme and exhibition

- Environment programme and exhibition
- Promotion of Traditional Art and Craft through empowering local artists
- Museum Art Explosion Against Corruption
- Museum Art Explosion Against Adolescent Pregnancy
- Museum Art Explosion For My Trash My Treasure
- Assist students and academicians in various projects and studies, etc.

The services undertaken by the museum have been filling gaps in the Tanzania education system through sharing resources and expertise by using collections, information, research results and skills. They have been applied to develop numerous products, video, films and fashions as media to improving Tanzanian education. For instance, schools and university students have been using the museum collections and information for projects and research reports.

Majority of the public has the notion that museums are places where old objects are kept and generally understood as places meant for international tourists. The main cause of this perception is lack of awareness on the museum functions which is supposed to be expressed through interactive and appealing exhibitions as well as accessible programmes, publications and website.

The internalization of the National Museum of Tanzania Strategic Plan (2003-2008) through stakeholders' recommendations led to the transformation of the museum so that it gives room for cultural practitioners, among other things, to exhibit, perform and contribute to the general understanding the role of the museum.

Unfortunately, the museum is yet to be fully equipped with all Tanzanian cultural and historical objects, record and information. There are few Tanzanian cultural and historical objects, records and information and documentaries (such as these of the Persians/Iranians) for exhibitions, school projects and research to allow the public access to cultural heritage information. The museum has been struggling to have enough objects, records and information as well as proper infrastructures to enable accessibility to the exhibitions, research and associated programmes that are relevant to target groups; children, youths, artists and cultural professionals/practitioners by using appropriate approaches and technologies. As a result, the stakeholders developed the museum infrastructures to become sustainable and contributing towards provision of quality education.

In this respect, the museum encompasses this strength and opportunity to host and implement this project (*the Understanding of the Contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in the Culture, History and Development of Tanzania*). The project will deal with historical and cultural heritage which must be collected, recorded/ documented and conserved/preserved for educations through displays, students' programs, projects and research as well as tourism. This project also holds an economic purpose as it will attract many tourists to visit the museum. The project aims at researching and acquiring objects, records and information of the Persian

(Iranian) communities in Tanzania which will provide more knowledge on culture, history and development of Tanzania.

Significance

The National Museum of Tanzania's vision insists on having a well-informed Tanzanian society that understands, appreciates, accesses and uses country's natural, cultural and historical heritage sustainably. The acquired museum objects, records and information are conserved purposely for education carried out in the form of projects, programmes and lectures.

The National Museum of Tanzania's mission pleads to be a custodian of the national heritage, committed to identification, collection, documentation, conservation, interpretation and dissemination of country's historical, cultural and natural heritage for the benefit of mankind through the enhanced research and curation facilities, heightened security, attractive, dynamic and interactive exhibitions and programs, adequate, skilled, motivated, creative and enthusiastic staff and volunteers, improved sources of income and proper management of resources, dialogue, partnership and networking with stakeholders, quality services and facilities, wide distribution of the museum in the country and promotion of public participation. Part of the Tanzanian public is the Persian (Iranian) communities in Tanzania which need to be accommodated in this museum mission.

The National Museum of Tanzania identifies a crucial aspect challenging the museum to be lacking substantial objects, records as well as information of various communities for attractive and interactive exhibition and programmes. The museum aims to enrich proper collection of objects, records and information, care and have a sustainable use of objects, records, information and infrastructures for the public. This provides the necessity for individuals, scholars, staff and affiliated users of the museum to conduct research and collection of objects, records and information for the purpose of disseminating cultural and natural information within the framework of the general National Museum of Tanzania legislation and regulations.

Currently, natural and cultural heritage sector has minimal programmes that forge links with the community and work in partnership with other institutions to contribute to the national cultural and natural strategy, promote and support cultural activities from the local artists and work to best practice standards in conservation and security within the museum environment. Producing exhibition and interactive programmes drawn from objects, records with researched information would encourage the Persian (Iranian) communities to come to the museum and other repeating visitors. The exhibition and programme would develop new audience in line with the National Museum of Tanzania policies and commitment to 'social inclusion' and 'community development'. It would also offer access to heritage services which will preserve historical and cultural collections; hereafter, the requisite of this project.

The National Museum of Tanzania board insists exhibitions and programs to be the foundation of the museum's communication to the public. For that reason, the Board, acting through the Director General and the Management are responsible for assuring that the scope of each exhibition and program agree with the National Museum of Tanzania vision and mission. This project builds a bridge to allow the museum communicate with the Persian (Iranian) communities and also gives a forum to the Persian (Iranian) communities to communicate with the rest of the public.

Through this project, the museum is eager to create a platform for stakeholders' partnership and networking for creating and promoting cultural and historical experiences, material expression, attractive and interactive programs. The project will give a room for the museum to dialogue with the Persian (Iranian) communities to provide the museum with objects, records and information to be able to produce quality exhibitions and programs as well as support for its development. Stakeholders' partnership (Persian (Iranian) communities) will be maintained mutually for production for exhibition and organizing festivals as well as programs together annually.

Challenges

The National Museum of Tanzania sets sights on creating exhibitions and programs that are enjoyable, inspirational and offer stimulating learning opportunities, engage visitors through innovative interpretation methods that help to relate the exhibitions and programs to their lives. With this, the Persian (Iranian) communities in Tanzania have been finding difficulties to be part of the museum as they strive to reflect their life in the museum.

Uneducative and unattractive exhibition and programs are associated with factors such as shortage of resources (funds/working tools), shortage of exhibition facilities, few researched and undocumented objects, records and information from different communities in Tanzania, lack of exhibition and programme technology (sound, light, ICT, stage) and shortage of skilled personnel. Museum objects, records and information are widely used in most research institutions as well as for educational and enjoyment purposes. Uneducative and unattractive museum programs, result into low museum publicity, continued public misconceptions of museum roles, low number of stakeholders using museum services, museum research value remain unrecognized, low visitation, unsustainability of museum operations and unfulfilled museum vision and mission.

It is unfortunate that the Tanzanian cultural traits and history have been affected by time, facts and history. The coming of foreigners, e.g. Persians, Indians, Chinese, Arabs, Europeans, etc. through early contacts and trade, colonialism and neo-colonials as well as religion (i.e. Islam and Christianity) influenced the Tanzanian culture and history in particular. Furthermore, globalization through media and liberal markets continue to impinge on Tanzanian culture history, and development. There is a need for the museum objects, records and information to be inclusive. Museum

storage rooms and galleries need to be inclusive. Exhibitions and programmes ought to be inclusive. Short of this, history, culture and development reflected on stored and displayed objects, records and information will be incomplete and uneducative.

SWOT Analysis

Strengths	Weaknesses
1. Good number of collections and information 2. The museum has space for organizing exhibition and programs 3. The museum has some materials and equipment for programs 4. The museum has specialists in some fields 5. The museum has good reputation to donors in handling programs 6. Museum is connected with the network system	1. Collections and information do not have diverse or representation coverage 2. Collection and information are not databased 3. It lacks specialty in space utilization 4. It has inadequate number of ICT equipment 5. It has neither have qualified exhibition/display officer nor logistic specialist 6. Museum programs are influenced by biasness from donors
Opportunities	Threats
1. More collections and information can be easily obtained from different communities 2. Retired civil servants may assist 3. The museum may acquire assistance from stakeholders 4. Museum has maintained good relationship with stakeholders 5. There is an increasing partnership between museum and museums, museum and universities and museum and natural resources institutions	1. Secret information cannot be revealed to the public 2. Retired civil servants may not be reliable 3. Other stakeholders may have limited time to participate 4. Natural disaster may affect plans 5. Changes within the government directives may interfere with museum's plans 6. Unreliable collection and information owners may limit museum plans 7. Bureaucracy in procurement procedures and in obtaining museum plan

One should bear in mind that together with these resources and little developments, there are still more challenges that need to be addressed to make the museum remain resourceful and more viable to the public. These challenges include:

- Limited cultural and historical objects, records and information to draw in the picture of the history, culture and development of Tanzania

- Lack of proper documentation of the Tanzanian history, culture and development
- Limited exhibitions and programs on Tanzanian history and culture
- Limited plans for preservation, conservation and presentation of this heritage to the public
- Limited plans for promotion strategy: There is lack of promotion of the museum functions to the public
- Lack of educational products and TV presentation: There is lack of awareness of cultural traits of different groups
- Few visitors particularly local ones
- Little revenue

Objectives

The museum aims at having inclusive objects, records and information as well as interactive, educative and attractive exhibition and program through incorporating stakeholders and application of modern equipment as well as ICT so that it becomes a home for everyone and an open public education resource centre with researched, preserved/conserved, documented and accessible cultural and historical heritage resources. To begin with, the museum in this project intends to start with researching and acquiring objects, records and information related to Persian (Iranian) communities which will enhance educative and attractive exhibition and programs.

Main Objective

The main objective is that, by the end of 2022 the museum in collaboration with Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have researched, acquired, preserved, conserved, exhibited and promoted the culture and history of Tanzania through the recognition of the contribution of the Persian (Iranian) communities in order to enable the public access the museum as a resource for education, scholarly research and recreation.

Specific Objectives

- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have researched and acquired objects, records and information of the Persian (Iranian) communities contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania
- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have recorded and documented objects, records and information of the Persian (Iranian) communities contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania
- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have conserved/preserved objects, records and information of the Persian (Iranian) communities contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania

- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have organized exhibition on objects, records and information of the Persian (Iranian) communities' contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania
- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have organized a program on the Persian (Iranian) communities' contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania
- By the end of 2021 the museum in collaboration with the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders shall have promoted and marketed Persian (Iranian) communities and their contribution to the culture, history and development of Tanzania

Activities

To implement this project, two types of activities are recommended: main and specific activities. The main activity will involve predominantly organizing a programme within a project which will bring in the Persian (Iranian) communities together to pledge their participation for the purpose of implementing this project. These communities through the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania in collaboration with the museum will raise funds with the assistance of outstanding members living in Dar Es Salaam and other regions. The prominent figures such as ministers, members of parliament and businessman will also be involved. This will be an Official Launch of the project, *Understanding the Contribution of the Persian (Iranian) Communities in the Culture, History and Development of Tanzania*.

Specific activities

- To identify possible funding individuals, companies and organizations
- To organize fund raising meeting with Museum, the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania and other stakeholders
- To arrange for stakeholders meeting
- To prepare solicitation letters and submit to sponsors
- To organize visitation to the companies for lobbying
- To identify sites and families where objects, records and information can be collected
- To research and acquire objects, records and information
- To document and digitize objects, records and information obtained
- To produce exhibits and artworks
- To mount the exhibition and program
- To advertise the exhibition and program
- To launch the exhibition and program for the public
- To organize the Persian (Iranian) – Tanzania cultural festival
- To produce a publication based on the research, exhibition and program
- To post the publication to the website for publicity

- To organize trainings on conservation, collection management, exhibition design and museum education
- To organize museum exchange of staff curatorial residences between Iran and Tanzania

Expected Output

- Donors and sponsors consulted
- Agreement for collaboration and sponsorship signed
- Stakeholders list drawn and mailed for a meeting
- Stakeholders and museum staff meeting held (report)
- Research and acquisition of objects, records and information collected
- Documentation and digitization of objects, records and information carried out
- Exhibits and artworks produced
- Exhibition and program mounted
- Exhibition and program advertised and promoted
- Exhibition and program launched
- Persian (Iranian) – Tanzania cultural festival organized
- Report of original researched and acquired objects, records and information printed
- Publication in the form of a book and catalogue of the given Persian/Iranian-Tanzania produced
- A special edition on the website of the whole project posted on the website
- Trainings on conservation, collection management, exhibition design and museum education organized
- museum exchange of staff curatorial residences between Iran and Tanzania organized
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Key Performance Indicators

- List of stakeholders and sponsors ready by 2020
- Draft of agreements ready by 2020
- Signed agreement ready by 2020
- Stakeholders and staff meeting held by 2020
- Research and acquisition report of objects, records and information ready by 2020/2021
- Documentation and digitization of objects, records and information report ready by 2021
- List of objects, artworks, storyline, floor plan for the exhibition ready by 2021
- Exhibition and program launched by 2021
- Persian (Iranian) – Tanzania cultural festival organized 2021
- Trainings on conservation, collection management, exhibition design and museum education organized by 2021

- Museum exchange of staff curatorial residences between Iran and Tanzania organized by 2021
- A special edition on the website of the whole project posted on the website by 2022
- Publication ready by 2023
- Evaluation Report ready by 2023

Requirement/inputs

1. Proposal with list of stakeholders, sponsors and budget
2. Museum staff, artists and stakeholders
3. Agreements (Memorandum of Understanding, etc.)
4. Research equipment (stationary, camera and decoder, flush, back up, etc.)
5. Laptops 2
6. Computers for digitization 2
7. Vehicle and fuel 1
8. Exhibition gears (showcases, pedestals, panels, etc.)
9. Program gears (decorations, lights and stage designing)
10. Media coverage and advertisements
11. Promotional materials
12. Master of ceremony
13. Refreshments
14. Administration and preparation costs
15. Publication
16. Website post

Tentative Budget in Shillings

S/ n.	Item	Unit	U/Price	Total
1.	Identification and compilation of the stakeholders, sponsors and budget	5 people x 10 days	500,000/	2,500,000/
2.	Museum staff and stakeholders involvement	6 people x 10 days	500,000/	3,000,000/
3.	Procurement procedures and Agreements (contracts, Memorandum of Understanding, etc.)	3 Meetings	2,000,000/	6,000,000/

4.	Research equipment (stationary, still and video camera and decoder, back up, etc.)	1 Video camera	8,000,000/	8,000,000
		1 still picture camera	3,000,000/	3,000,000
		1 Recorder	300,000/	300,000
		2 Back up	250,000/	500,000
		1 Stationary	400,000/	400,000
		Subtotal		12,200,000
5.	Researchers and research assistants	4Researchersx30days	100,000/	12,000,000
		2Ass researchersx30d	50,000/	3,000,000
		Subtotal		15,000,000
6.	Laptop	2 Laptop	4,000,000/	8,000,000
7.	Computers and printers for digitization	2 Mac Computers	3,500,000/	7,000,000
		2 Printers	250,000/	500,000
		Subtotal		7,500,000
8.	Exhibition gears (showcases, pedestals, panels, etc.)	7 showcases	1,000,000/	7,000,000
		7 pedestals	200,000/	1,400,000
		7 panels	300,000/	2,100,000
		Subtotal		10,500,000
9.	Program gears (Decoration Light & stage)	20 Sports lights	200,000/	4,000,000
		10 Tube lights	50,000/	500,000
		10 Led Lights	500,000/	5,000,000
		Cables	1000,000/	1,000,000
		Accessories	1000,000/	1,000,000
		Subtotal		11,500,000
10.	Media coverage and advertisements	4-Tv stations	1000,000/	4,000,000
		4-Redio stations	1000,000/	4,000,000
		4-Newspapers	100,000/	400,000

			Subtotal	8,400,000
11.	Promotional materials	Lamp sum	5,500,000/	5,500,000
12.	MC	Lamp sum	1000,000/	1,000,000
13.	Refreshments	Lamp sum	7,300,000/	7,300,000
14.	Administration costs 3,000,000/	Lamp sum		3,000,000
15.	Publication (magazine 9,700,000/	Lamp sum		9,700,000
16.	Fuel for a vehicle 3,500,000/	Lamp sum		3,500,000
17.	Festival 20,000,000	Lamp sum		20,000,000
18.	Trainings 10,000,000	Lamp sum		10,000,000
19.	Exchange program	Lamp sum 30,000,000		30,000,000
	Grand Total			163,100,000

Conclusion

The fraternity between the Persian (Iranian) communities and Tanzanians has lasted for a long period. Both the Persian (Iranian) communities and Tanzanians have lived together in harmony. They have made history together. There are more cultural traits being shared by both communities. Their culture and history have made Tanzania be what it is currently. It is high time that both sides celebrate their lives together. The National Museum of Tanzania (Museum and House of Culture) and the Iranian Embassy to Tanzania ought to create this platform for these celebrations for the entire public.